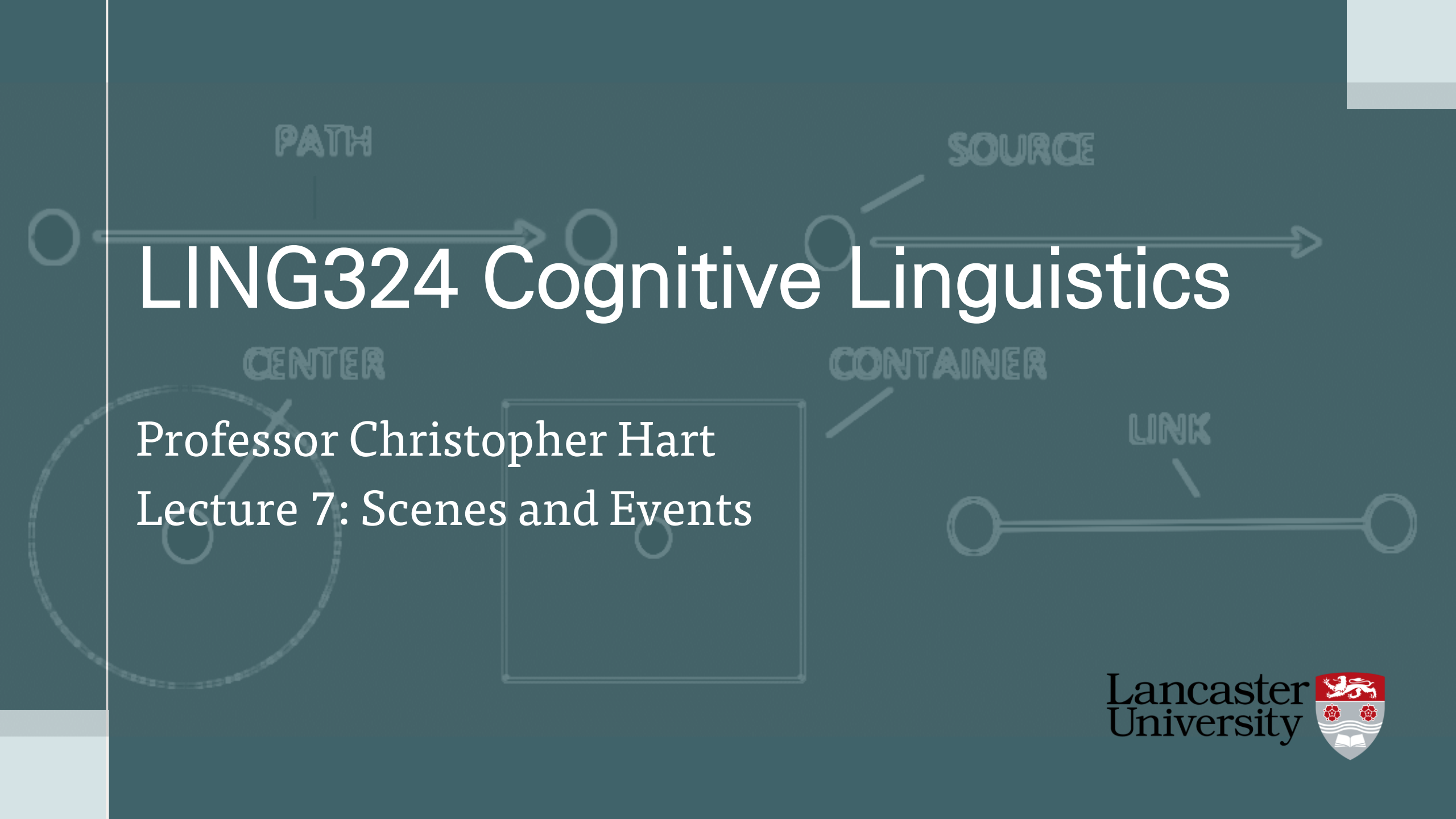




LING324 Cognitive Linguistics

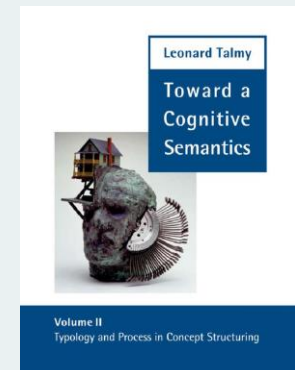
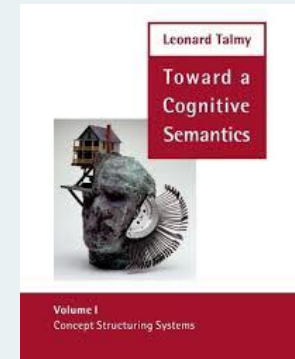
Professor Christopher Hart
Lecture 7: Scenes and Events

Overview

- Introduction
- Figure/Ground
- Concept structuring systems
- Domains: Space and Time
- Concept structuring systems:
 - Configurational system
 - Attentional system
 - Perspectival system
- The Motion event
- Fictive motion
- Force-dynamics

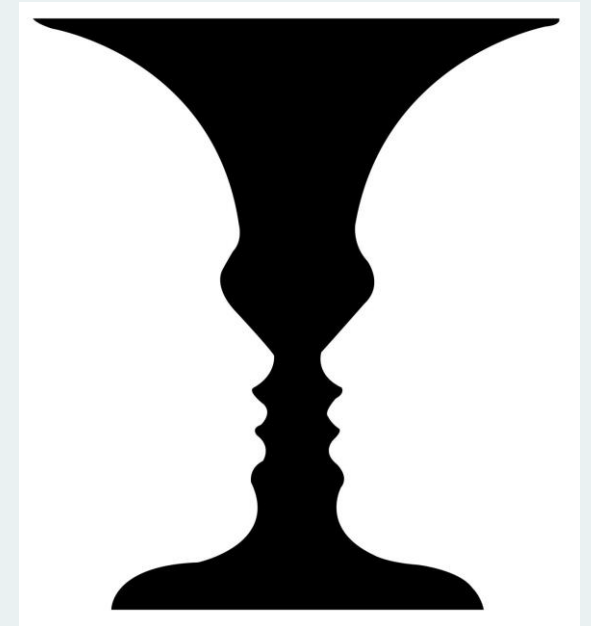
Introduction

- Structuring of scenes and events addressed in **cognitive semantics** (Talmy 2000a/b)
- Focusses on conceptual specifications inherent in linguistic representation of events
 - Reflect embodied experience
 - “Abstract, idealized and often virtually geometric delineations” (Talmy 2000a: 13)
- Link between semantic constituents within conceptual complex and syntactic constituents within a sentence – **meaning-form mappings**



Figure/Ground

- Linguistic forms in discourse organise **cognitive representation** (CR) of target situation
- Most obvious way scene organised in CR is **Figure/Ground**
- Reflective of perceptual experience
- Based on objective properties
 - E.g. size; fixity of location; geometric complexity; topicality; dependency; saliency
- Encoded in language through **Subject/Object** distinction
 1. The bike stood near the house
 2. ?The house stood near the bike

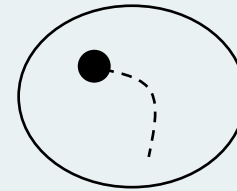


Figure/Ground

- Typical **geometries** of Figure and Ground

- F reduces to geometric point

3. The statue is in the park at the end of the path



- Exceptions:

4. The board lay across the railway track

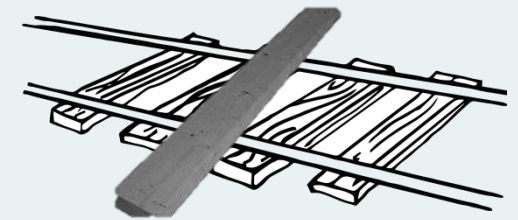
[F = linear]

5. The tablecloth lay over the table

[F = planar]

6. The odour spread throughout the room

[F = 3-D distributed quantity]



- Further specifications in (x): axis of F horizontal; axes of F and G perpendicular; plane of F parallel to plane of G; F touches both of G's edges; extension of F not enormously greater than width of G on either side

Figure/Ground

- G exhibits more elaborate range of geometric distinctions:

5. The bike stood near the tree	[G = single point]
6. The bike stood between the trees	[G = point pair]
7. The bike stood among the trees	[G = set of points]
8. The bike stood amidst the trees	[G = aggregate mass]
9. The bike sped across the field	[G = bounded plane]
10. The bike sped into the sports hall	[G = container]
11. The bike sped through the tunnel	[G = linear enclosure]

- Asymmetry of parts:

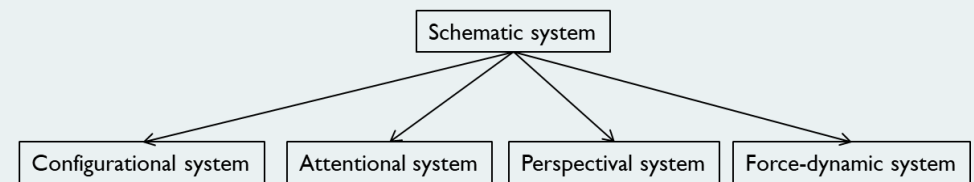
12. The bike is

{	in front of	}	the church
	in back of behind		
	to left/right of		



Concept Structuring Systems

- Beyond Figure/Ground
- Two systems contribute meaning to CR:
 - **Content** system – associated primarily with open-class (lexical) elements
 - **Schematic** system – associated primarily with closed-class (grammatical) elements
- Four schematic sub-systems described
- **Conceptual alternativativity**



Thus, much as certain linguistic forms in a portion of discourse organise a referent situation in terms of configurational structure, so other linguistic forms specify where one is to locate one's perspective point from which to regard the now-structured referent situation ... Still further linguistic forms specify the particular distribution of attention that one is to direct over the structured situation from one's adopted perspective point. (Talmy 2000a: 12)

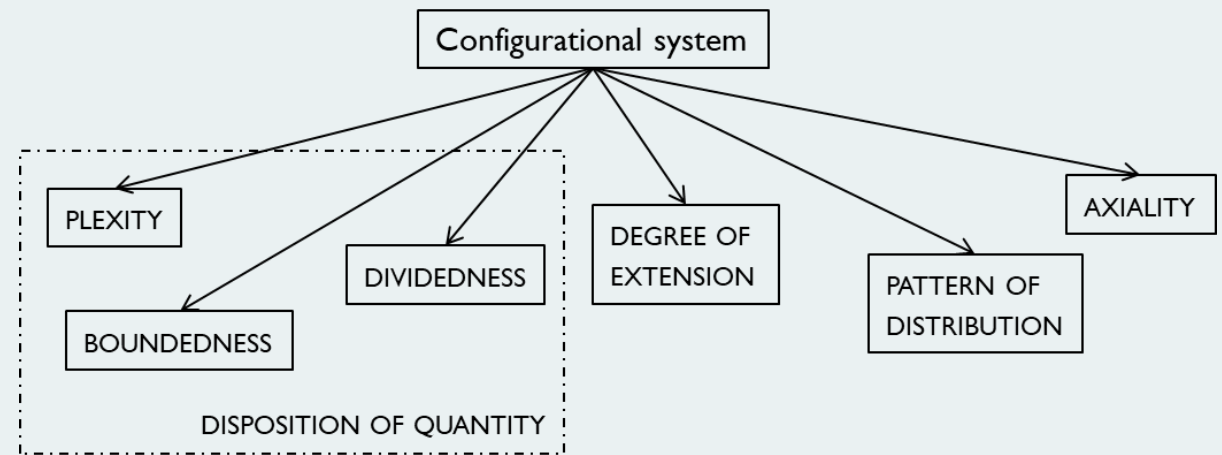
Domains: Space and Time

- Structuring systems generalise across space and time
- Homologous categories – shared structuring principles, e.g. quantity
 - **Matter** (space) vs. **action** (time)
- **Continuous** vs. **discrete** (dividedness)
- Conversion between domains
 - **E.g. Reification** (action → matter)
 - 13. Ivy washed her → Ivy gave her a wash (discrete)
 - 14. Ivy helped her → Ivy gave her some help (continuous)

Domain	Continuous	Discrete
Space (matter)	Mass (<i>water</i>)	Objects (<i>bike</i>)
Time (action)	Activity (<i>sleep</i>)	Acts (<i>breathe</i>)

Configurational System

- Provides structure to the spatial and temporal properties of scenes and events
- Distinctions encoded by both open- and closed-class elements
- Six schematic categories



Configurational System

- Plexity
 - **Uniplex** = quantity consisting of only one element
 - **Multiplex** = quantity consisting of multiple elements
 - Encoded through **number** (singular vs. plural) and **lexical aspect** (semelfactive vs. iterative)
- Boundedness
 - **Bounded** = quantity conceived as having boundary
 - **Unbounded** = quantity conceived as without boundary
 - Encoded through **count/mass** and **grammatical aspect** (perfect vs. imperfect)
 - **Bounding** vs. **portion excerpting**

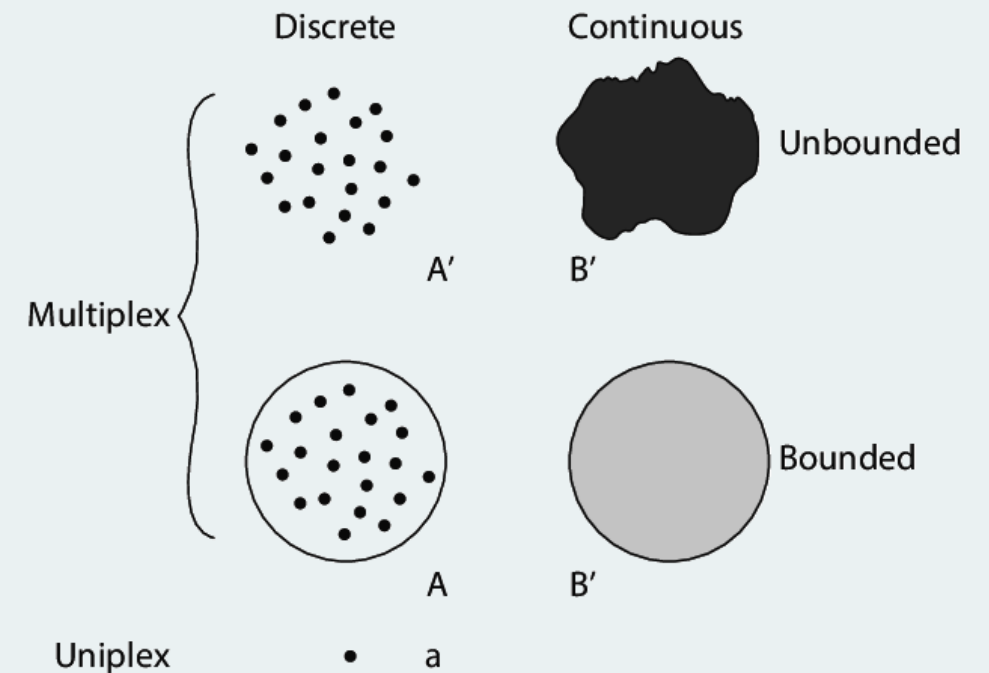
	MATTER	ACTION
<i>Uniplex</i>	A bird flew in	He sighed (<i>once</i>)
<i>Multiplex</i>	Birds flew in	He <i>kept</i> sighing

	MATTER	ACTION
<i>Bounded</i>	He drank a glass of champagne	He left the party
<i>Unbounded</i>	He drank champagne	He is leaving the party

Configurational System

- Dividedness, plexity and boundedness together provide **disposition of quantity**

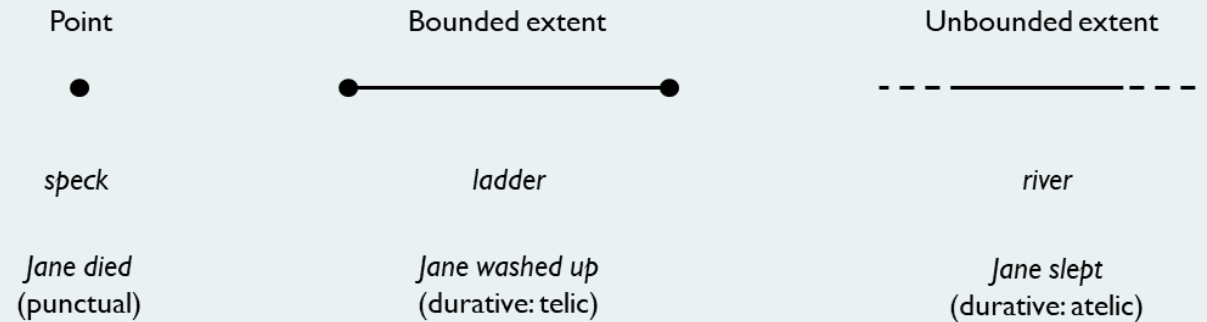
	Dividedness	Plexity	Boundedness
<i>Furniture</i> (to) breathe	Discrete	Multiplex	Unbounded
<i>Water</i> (to) sleep	Continuous	Multiplex	Unbounded
(a) family (to) molt	Discrete	Multiplex	Bounded
(a) sea (to) empty	Continuous	Multiplex	Bounded
(a) bike (to) sigh	Discrete	Uniplex	Bounded



(Talmy 2000a: 59)

Configurational System

- Degree of extension
 - Point vs. extent
 - Encoded through lexical aspect (telicity)
 - Intersects with boundedness

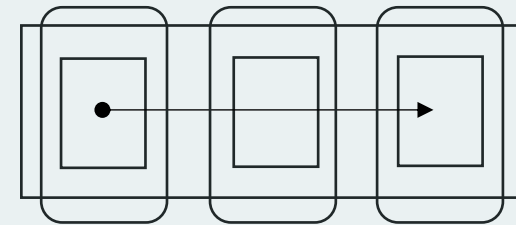


Attentional System

- Distributes attention over matter and action
- Patterns of attention:
 - **Focus of attention:** Figure/Ground organisation
 - **Window of attention** (path windowing):

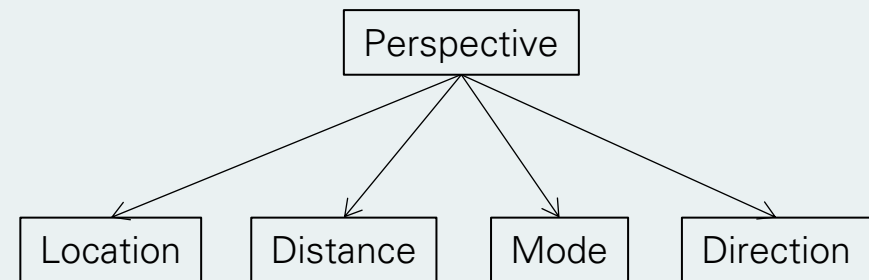
15.	The cargo fell from the plane	[initial]
16.	The cargo fell through the sky	[medial]
17.	The cargo fell into the sea	[final]
 - **Level of attention**

18.	The group decided ...
19.	Members of the group decided ...



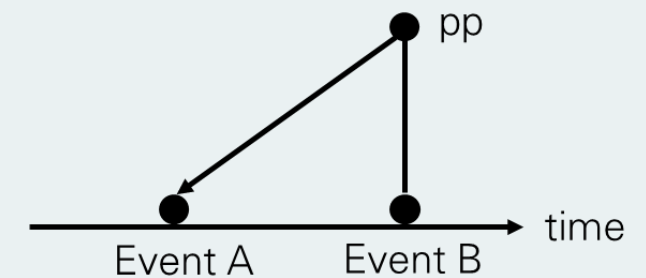
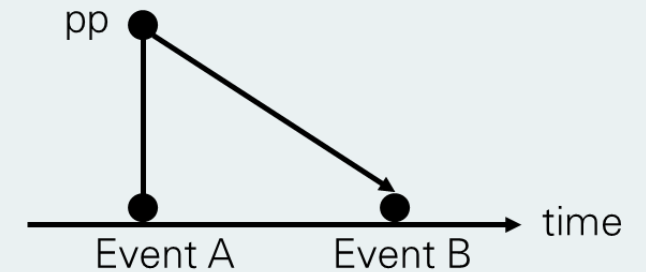
Perspectival System

- Establishes a viewpoint from which scene or event construed
- Four schematic categories
- **Location:**
 20. **Interior:** The office door slowly opened and two men walked in
 21. **Exterior:** The two men slowly opened the office door and walked in



Perspectival System

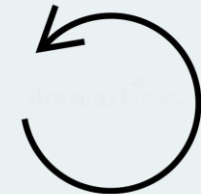
- Mode:
 - 22. **Synoptic**: There are some houses in the valley
 - 23. **Sequential**: There is a house every now and then throughout the valley
- Direction:
 - 24. **Prospective**: I shopped at the store before I went home
 - 25. **Retrospective**: After I shopped at the store, I went home



Motion Events

- A situation containing motion or continuation of stationary location (Talmy 2000b)
 - **Translational** motion as opposed to rotation, oscillation etc.
- Six conceptual components:
 - **Figure; Ground; Motion; Path; Manner; Cause**

26. The ball rolled down the slope
 [Figure] [Motion + Manner] [Path] [Ground]



Motion Events

- Linked with clause constituents in different ways
 - Path expressed through prepositions or verbs
 - **Satellite-framed** vs. **verb-framed** languages
 - Manner expressed through verbs or adverbial modifiers
 - Non-obligatory in V-languages

S-languages
(e.g. English)

The bottle floated into the cave

motion manner path

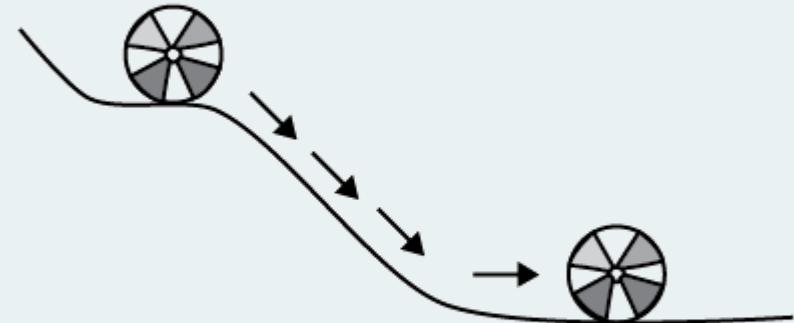
V-languages
(e.g. Spanish)

La botella entró a la cueva (flotando)

(Talmy 2000b: 49)

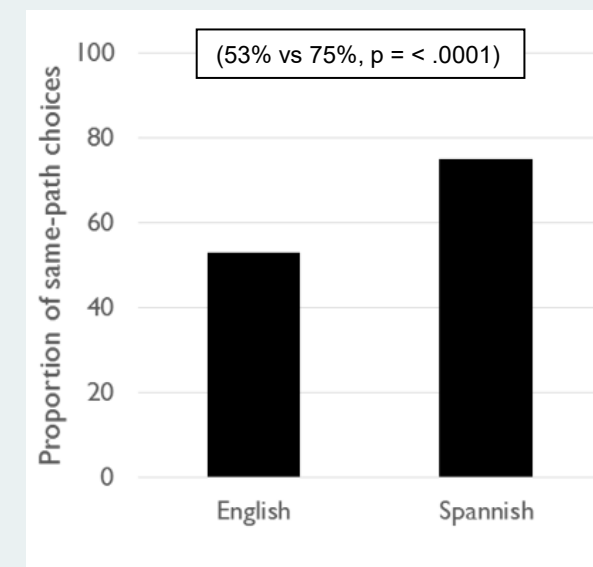
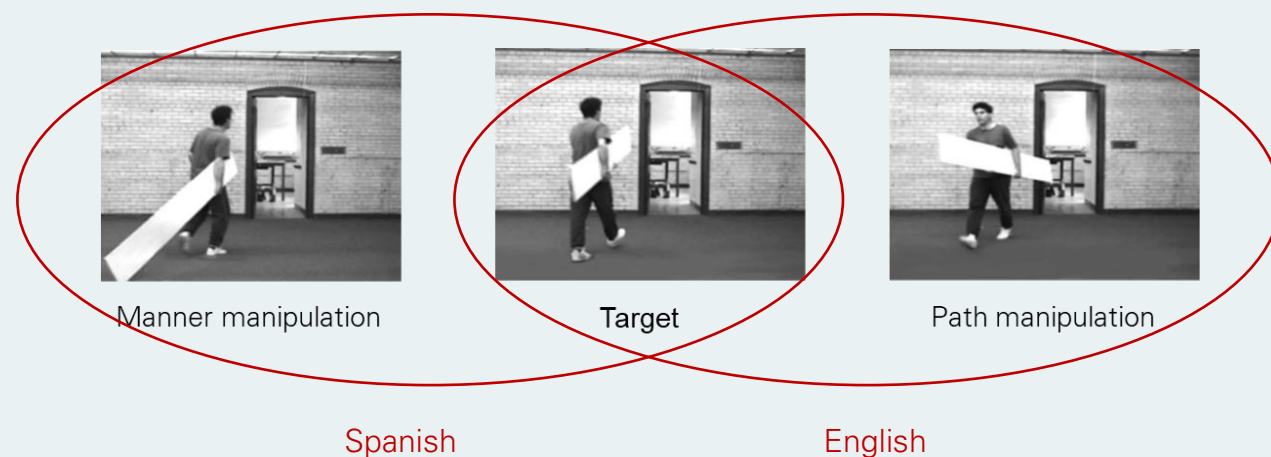
Motion Events

- Types of motion
 - **Object motion:**
 - 27. The ball rolled down the slope
 - **Self-motion:**
 - 28. We rolled down the slope
 - **Caused motion:**
 - 29. The car was pushed down the slope



Motion Events

- Manner optional in Spanish but obligatory in English
 - Hypothesis: English speakers should pay more attention to manner than Spanish speakers, who pay more attention to path (Gennari et al. 2002)
 - Which video is most similar to target video?



(Gennari et al. 2002)

Fictive Motion

- Static scenes construed dynamically as motional

Languages systematically and extensively refer to stationary circumstances with forms and constructions shoes basic reference is to motion (Talmy 2000a: 104)

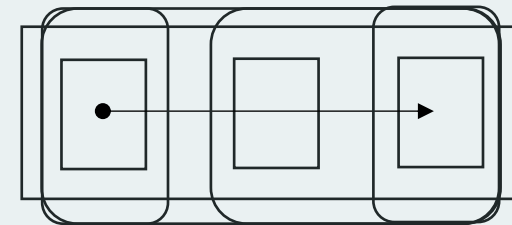
30. The mountain range lies (longitudinally) between Canada and Mexico (factive)
31. The mountain range goes from Canada to Mexico (fictional motion)
32. The mountain range goes from Mexico to Canada (fictional motion)



Fictive Motion

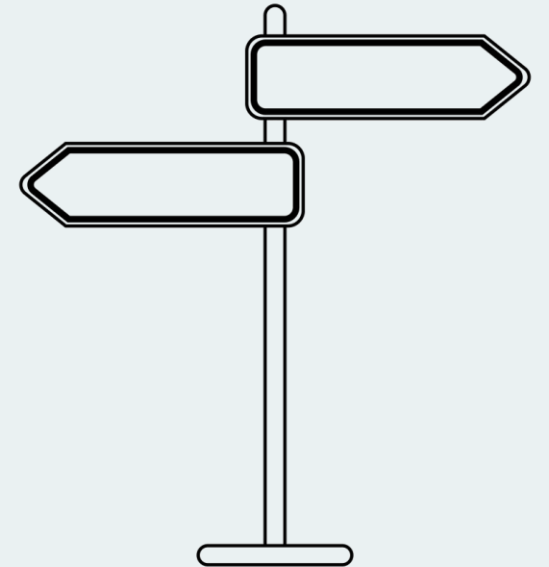
- Fictive paths
 - Spatial configuration understood as static
conceptually sequentialised to include path of fictive motion
 - Trajectory exhibited as focus of attention shifts over scene
 - X BE across Y from Z construction
 - Subject to windowing of attention

- 33. My bike is across the street from the bakery [maximal windowing]
Ivy sat across the table from Wilbur
- 34. My bike is across from the bakery [medial gapping]
Ivy sat across from Wilbur
- 35. My bike is across the street [initial gapping]
Ivy sat across the table



Fictive Motion

- Other types of fictive path (Talmy 2000a: 106-139)
 36. **Orientation:** The arrow on the signpost pointed toward the town
 37. **Radiation:** The sun is shining into the cave
 38. **Shadow:** The tree cast its shadow down into the valley
 39. **Sensory:** The enemy can see us from where they're positioned



Force-Dynamic System

- Structures events conceived as forceful
- Constitutes **naïve physics** of conceptual system
- Generalises over **causation** to also include relations of letting, helping and hindering
- Lexical and grammatical representation
 - *Push, pull, stay, remain, block, stop, overpower*
 - *Against* (preposition), *because/despite* (conjunction), *keep* (auxiliary)
- Extends metaphorically to social and psychological domains
- Characterises grammatical category of modal verbs
 - *Can, may, should, could, must ...*

a. Force entities

Agonist (Ago):



Antagonist (Ant):



c. Balance of strenghts

stronger entity: +

weaker entity: -

b. Intrinsic force tendency

toward action:



toward rest:



d. Resultant

action:



rest:



Force-Dynamic System

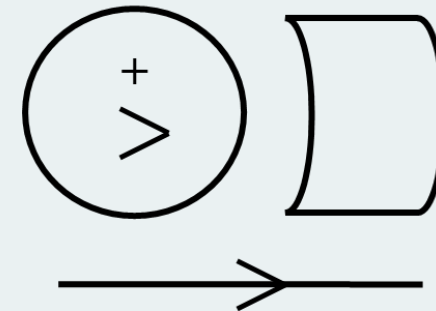
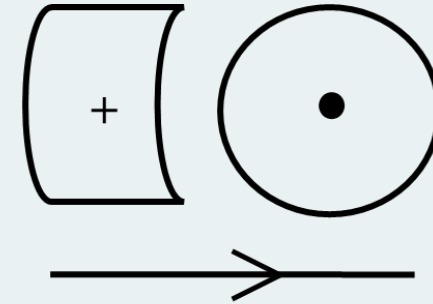
- Be Vping / keep Vping

40. The ball was rolling along the green

41. The ball kept on rolling along the green

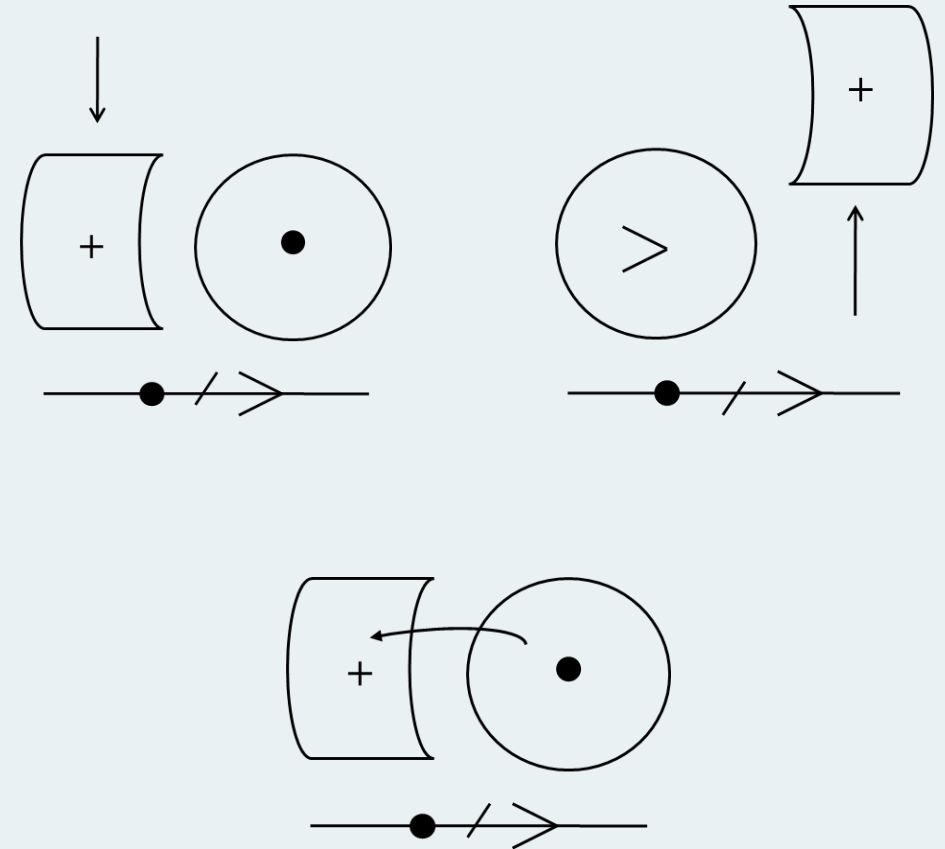
42. The ball kept rolling because of the wind blowing on it

43. The ball kept rolling despite the stiff grass



Force-Dynamic System

- **Steady-state** vs. **shift-in-state** patterns
- Onset causation and letting:
 - 44. The ball's hitting it made the lamp topple from the table
 - 45. The plugs coming loose let the water flow from the tank
- **Shift in balance of strength:**
 - 46. The enemy overcame us as we stood defending the border



Force-Dynamic System

- Extends to inter-psychosocial and intra-psychological experience:

47. Peer pressure pushed Wilbur into smoking

48. Ivy persuaded Wilbur to stop smoking

49. Wilbur resisted the temptation to smoke

50. Wilbur gave in to the temptation to smoke

Force-Dynamic System

- Accounts for **deontic** and **epistemic** senses of modal verbs (Talmy 2000; Sweetser 1990)
- Deontic: permission/obligation
 - 51. The cake can/may/should/must stay in the box
- Epistemic: truth/certainty
 - 52. The pear could/may/should/must be ripe by now
- Epistemic senses derived metaphorically from deontic
 - Evidence and reason act as antagonist
 - *Must* = 'the available evidence forces me to the conclusion that P'
 - *May* = 'I am not barred by any alternative evidence from drawing the conclusion that P'

Thank you

Selected References

- Gennari, S.P., S.A. Sloman, B.C. Malt and W.T. Fitch (2002). Motion events in language and cognition. *Cognition* 83: 49-79.
- Matlock, T. (2004). The conceptual motivation of fictive motion. In G. Radden & R. Dirven (eds.), *Studies in linguistic motivation*. Mouton de Gruyter. pp. 221-248.
- Pourcel, S. (2010). Motion: A conceptual typology. In B. Bergen, V. Evans & J. Zinken (eds.), *Language, Cognition and Space: The State of the Art and New Directions*. Equinox. pp.419-449.
- Talmy, L. (2000a). *Toward a Cognitive Semantics, vol. I: Concept Structuring Systems*. MIT Press.
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